A CODE FOR PUBLIC GOOD

INDIA IS WELL ON ITS WAY TOWARDS AFFORDABLE, ACCESSIBLE AND INCLUSIVE DELIVERY OF PUBLIC SERVICES. NOW IT HAS TO SCALE UP AND PROVIDE EQUAL ACCESS



Call it Gram Swaraj 2.0. Where no village, however remote its location, falls off the grid when it comes to the delivery of public services. Where state and citizen are linked on a simple hotline: the mobile phone. Making this possible is open source software (OSS), an affordable, easy-to-use and customisable platform that makes it the ideal vehicle for governments to dispense public services in leak-proof ways. That's especially useful in a country like ours, which has overtaken China this year to become the most populous in the world, and whose people are strung across diverse geographies. India has already built a digital public infrastructure on a scale unimaginable in other countries. The National eGovernance Plan has 31 Mission Mode projects, covering the entire gamut of government-to-citizen interactions, from health to agriculture to banking to taxation to education and more. The challenge now is to improve accessibility and to make it wholly inclusive.

WHY IT IS A GAME CHANGER

With faster, accurate and user-friendly digital services, OSS-based platforms can not only provide quality services, they can also be suitably scaled up. At the same time, such services remain dynamic and flexible enough to respond to any changes in demand and technological evolution.

India has been one of the leading countries in the world in the adoption of open-source platforms to provide e-governance. Indian government agencies are involved in several public-private collaborations to develop OSS. In fact, most of the popular e-governance services, be it UMANG or Ayushman Bharat, are based on OSS. "Organisations and government agencies involved in creating digital public infrastructure have been building micro-services architecture, the kind used by Meta or Google, at a minimal cost. Once built, government and private sectors can come together to deliver e-governance to our huge population," says Viraj Tyagi, founder of e-Gov Foundation, a non-profit involved in building the digital governance ecosystem.

The preference for OSS is growing because of its flexibility and cost-effectiveness. Government agencies can easily tailor open-source products to fit their specific needs. Besides, open-source licences do not limit or restrict usage. Nor is there any vendor monopoly when using free and open standards. The Union and state governments have, therefore, been opting for OSS in delivering digital services.

THE CHANGE-MAKERS

E-GOV FOUNDATION

The Bengaluru-based non-profit has built and deployed a tech stack called DIGIT (Digital Infrastructure for Governance, Impact and Transformation) to transform urban governance